strictures of the *shtetl*, replacing it with an egalitarian society of secular pioneers, hardy men and women who worked the land and fought to defend their borders. Theodor Herzl, the father of Zionism, imagined that the diaspora would eventually disappear, with the entirety of world Jewry concentrated in Israel. “Whoever can, will, and must perish, let him perish. But the distinctive nationality of Jews neither can, will, nor must be destroyed,” he wrote in his 1896 pamphlet *Der Judenstaat*. “Whole branches of Judaism may wither and fall, but the trunk will remain.”

The pioneers came and settled. But then the country moved on, from socialism to neoliberalism, collective farms to start-ups. The superstitions did not die out but rather endured; the new Hebrews saw their numbers shrink, while the scions of the *shtetl* multiplied. The diaspora did not disappear. World Jewry cleaved in half, one part in Israel, the other largely concentrated in a Western world that became tolerant and open in a way Herzl never dreamt. The vision became obsolete, and nothing took its place. “It is difficult to define Zionism,” the World Zionist Organization ironically notes on its website. “But in general, one can say that Zionism is love for the land of Israel, loyalty to the state, and a desire to live in it, despite the difficulties.”

It is true that many nations, not just Israel, have only a vague definition of their identity. *The Citizen’s Almanac*, an educational booklet for immigrants published by the US government, does not even try to define “Americanism”. It only lists the rights and responsibilities of a citizen. But that is exactly the point: American identity is deliberately vague because it is meant to be expansive. When it lives up to its ideals, it can accommodate both the evangelical white farmer in Iowa and the secular daughter of Hindu immigrants in New York.

There are scholars who argue that nationalism is inherently illiberal, because it differentiates between citizens and non-citizens. Maybe so, in a utopian world. But human history suggests that we are not ready to stop dividing ourselves into groups—so the question is what kind of nationalism we practice. And the Western world, in general, has come a long way from nineteenth-century conceptions of nationalism, which were rooted in ethnic identity. This is not to argue that countries like the US are fully “post-racial”, as many commentators proclaimed in 2008. Still, the fact that the previous American president was the grandson of a Muslim goat herder from Kenya suggests a certain degree of progress.